

The Most Overused Word

Love.

Perhaps the most overused word in the world.

We love our mothers. We also love our phones. We write it on cards and forget it by evening. Said so often, it has almost stopped meaning anything.

And yet, when it comes to Amma, no other word will do. Not because it is easy. Because it is exact.

She does not just speak of love. She is love, in human form.

1953. A small fishing village on the coast of Kerala. A girl was born into a humble family of fisherfolk. Poverty was everywhere around them, but prayer was part of every day.

As a small child, she was already in love with the unseen. She sang to her beloved Krishna, songs she made up herself, as if he were sitting right beside her. Lost in those songs, she forgot everything else.

The village had seen devotion before. Never like this. Her longing was so intense that her own family began to say she had lost her mind.

But her love for God did not take her away from the world. It led her deeper into it.

She bathed the elderly in the neighbouring houses. Washed their clothes. Cleaned their homes. No one asked her to. She simply could not look away.

She saw the sick who could not afford medicine. Some could not afford even a small piece of cotton for the injection that would ease their pain. Not the medicine. Just the cotton. And because they could not afford even that, they lay crying in pain.

She could not bear it.

The sorrow of the world burned in her so fiercely that, as she would later share, she once thought of giving up her own life. That is how deeply she felt the pain of others.

But that fire did not consume her. It became a lamp.

And so she began to hold people. A grieving mother. A frail old man. A frightened child. Whoever came to her.

"A natural flow of motherhood overwhelmed me," she would later say, "and I began to embrace whoever came to me, like a mother."

Day by day, her devotion deepened, and so did the worry around her. Her family and neighbours were now certain she had gone mad.

But when a flower blooms, no one has to invite the bees.

They came on their own. First a few young seekers, then more. Some came to see her and never left. In 1981, the small circle around her became an ashram.

And still they came, from every corner of the world. Engineers. Doctors. Scientists. Scholars. Brilliant minds who found in her something no degree had ever given them.

The girl they once called mad, the world now calls Amma. Mother.

In those early years, Amma decided to build a Kali temple at the ashram. There was very little money. She began anyway, and everyone at the ashram joined the work.

Then one day, a few people came to her from a place called Paripally. They brought heavy news. There was an orphanage there, and the family running it could no longer keep it going. The children were going hungry. Many were sick. People with bad intentions had begun to exploit them. Would Amma take them in?

She did not think twice. The money saved for the temple went to the orphanage, and she sent her disciples to care for the children.

The temple could wait. The children could not.

This is Amma. For her, nothing is more sacred than serving those in need. The world is the temple. And the people in it are the deity.

Slowly, her love learned to build. She looked at what each disciple knew and gave them work to match. She asked the scholars to start schools and colleges. She asked the doctors to build a hospital. Not to make money. To serve.

The schools grew into a network across India. The colleges grew into a university of more than 24,000 students.

But the hospital was her oldest dream. Since she was a young girl, she had longed for a place where even the poorest could receive world-class care. In 1998, that dream opened its doors in Kochi.

Once, she watched her neighbours cry over a piece of cotton they could not afford. By 2025, her hospital had given free medical care worth ₹890 crore to more than 6.6 million people.

And the dream kept growing. Charitable hospitals where every treatment is free. And in 2022, in Faridabad, India's largest private hospital.

Yet for Amma, free care was only half the answer. She wanted the best of healthcare to be something even the poor could afford. So she encouraged her doctors and academics to research and invent, and to find better treatments that cost less. A low-cost insulin pump. A low-cost screening tool for oral cancer. Innovation, with the poor in mind.

That is why Amrita Hospitals has grown into one of the largest research and innovation hubs in the country.

Everything she builds carries the same signature. Love, and a care beyond anything we could imagine.

To know more, visit www.amritaimpact.com

The same love that once bathed an elderly neighbour now reaches millions.

10 million meals, every year.

More than 47,000 homes. They began when she heard the cries of women who spent whole nights mopping rainwater out of their thatched huts.

55,000 scholarships, so that poverty does not end a child's education.

200,000 women given work, for many of them the first job of their lives.

Lifetime pensions for 100,000 widows, people with disabilities and women in poverty.

When disaster strikes anywhere in the world, Amma sends her children. From Gujarat to Japan. From Haiti to Nepal. From the Kerala floods to the war in Ukraine.

First with food, shelter, medicine and comfort. Then with homes, livelihoods and a way forward. From the need of the moment to a secure future.

The 2004 tsunami shows what that means.

On 26 December, the waves reached Amma's own shore. Rescue began even as the water rushed toward the ashram. Six million free meals in the first six months. Then years of rebuilding. 6,200 homes. 700 new fishing boats. Creative therapy for 10,000 children, even swimming lessons. Training for 2,500 young people. A bridge, so the village would always have a way out. ₹200 crore in all, and volunteer hours no one could count.

Many survivors said something remarkable. Their lives were better after the tragedy than before it.

That is her idea of relief. Not only to help people survive. To help them rise.

Her love does not stop at people. To Amma, nature is a mother too.

More than a million trees planted around the world. GreenFriends volunteers in over 50 countries. Millions of seed balls scattered to bring back forests, some even from helicopters. 30,000 trees along 13 kilometres of Kerala's coast.

And when the pandemic brought the world to a standstill, her volunteers planted trees in humility, asking Mother Nature to forgive the harm we have done to her.

In 2022, Amma became the first spiritual leader to chair the Civil 20, the voice of civil society at the G20. Its message reached millions around the world in four simple words.

You are the Light.

Through it all, she has never stopped doing what she began with. She holds people.

More than 40 million of them. At times, for 22 hours without a break.

In her arms, people pour out their sorrows. Illness. Debt. Loneliness. Loss. And every hospital, every school, every home, every rebuilt village is her answer to what she hears there.

That is why the world knows her work by a simple name. Embracing the World.

Love.

We have said it so often, we almost forgot what it could do.

In the dictionary, love is a noun. In Amma, it is a verb.

It turns sorrow into light. It bathes an elderly neighbour. It lets a temple wait, so children can eat. It rebuilds a coastline. It plants a forest. It holds 40 million people, one at a time.

And her prayer for the world is still a simple one. That everyone may sleep without fear, at least for one night. That everyone may eat their fill, at least for one day.

Love. Perhaps the most overused word in the world.

Until someone lives it.